

disappointed faces told me that 1982 was *not* the year for that particular model. We took my friend's pre-owned, two-year-old Lexus to lunch after that.)

My new coworkers were not shallow. They just had grown up differently than I had. I grew up wearing the same pair of jeans for as many years as it took to wear out the knees. When they became too worn or outdated to wear in public, I threw them on to work in the garden or do farm chores (which consumed much of our time). Nothing was done away with simply because there was a newer, slicker alternative on the market. My new coworkers, on the other hand, had always lived or worked in the city, came from homes with double incomes, and spent more time traveling than at home. While neither way was better, I was reeling from the new pressures.

I managed to appear on the outside that I was keeping up. I parked my car far away from the office building, made friends with the mailroom employees (who were younger and more easygoing), and planned my road back to a simpler lifestyle. Seven years after I moved away from my tiny rural town, I've moved back again.

Right away, I noticed that nothing much had changed. I recognized my neighbors right away, because they

were still driving the car they drove when I was in junior high. *If it ain't broke, don't fix it.* Since it was largely still a farming community, no one gave me a second look when I popped into town with muddy tennis shoes and a tore-up baseball cap. I wondered what my old friends from work would have said.

And while I still keep in touch with my dearest pals from the city, the gap gets wider every year. They talk Mommy-and-Me classes and shoes, while I talk 0-point turning mowers and how much my kids enjoy pulling weeds. Do I see farmers in my community go overboard, being consumed by materialism and competing with their neighbors for a faster boat, bigger truck, and greener yard? Sure. But it is far easier to avoid the rat race when there's eight acres between myself and the next rat.

